

SECRETS OF THE DIVINE

the Kabbalah tradition

▼ Celestial ladder

Taken from Ramon Llull's work *De Nova Logica*, this woodcut illustrates his concept of organizing ideas as a ladder. The ascending steps, or ladder, signify moving up from everyday life into celestial realms.



Kabbalah beliefs are notorious for occult leanings and for being kept secret: one such belief, that humans share divine “sparks” from the godhead, helps promote this sense of mysterious knowledge. Different spellings include Kabbalah, Cabbala, and Qabalah and these are often associated with specific traditions, such as Judaism, Christianity, and Hermeticism, or occult practices. The form Kabbalah is often used as a general term.

Many Renaissance kabbalistic ideas stem from medieval Jewish magical mysticism, which included esoteric methods such as the use of symbols (specifically of the Hebrew alphabet) to interpret the Tanakh (Jewish bible). A fertile mixture of Jewish-Islamic esoteric traditions emerged in countries with Islamic and Arabic populations, such as Spain, that gave rise to other kabbalistic practices including the use of arcane symbols and talismans to pursue mystical knowledge. Cryptic signs, letters, and numbers were at the core of Western Kabbalah, too.

Christian Kabbalah

A Christian form of Kabbalah flourished in the Renaissance, colored by the era's Hermeticism (see pp.134–135). Christian Kabbalists explored complex notions of the universe's unity and eventually embraced all religions, gaining Kabbalah a vital place in the West's history of magic.

One precursor to Renaissance Kabbalah was the work of 13th-century Christian mystic Ramon Llull of Majorca. Some now see his theories in a semi-kabbalistic way, including his use of figures similar to the *sephiroth* (see p.89) in Jewish Kabbalah. Early Christian Kabbalah was also influenced by the many

► Esoteric doctrine

A colored version of the important tree of life illustration from Gikatilla's influential *Gates of Light*. The tree's 10 spheres relate to 10 emanations that represent God's divine nature and creative energies.

